own party – to respond firmly to the situation, even if it meant a forced exchange of populations or military action against Pakistan.

Such views were particularly popular in Bengal, where the leaders like the minister of industries and supplies Syama Prasad Mookerjee, supported by the Bengali press, had been scathing in their criticism of Nehru's attitude to Pakistan. Nehru, on the other hand, was determined to avoid any military action and considered the rousing of popular passions as an attempt to bully him into war. It was in this volatile situation that Sardar Patel spoke to Congress MPs, and apparently undermined Nehru's position as Prime Minister by expressing strong disapproval of the direction of his foreign policy.[29]

While Nehru laid out his case for not taking any precipitate action – the intimate connection between Indo-Pak issues and domestic communal problems where protection of minorities was closely tied to avoidance of military action against Pakistan – and expressed his displeasure at his deputy pulling in a different direction, it is Patel's reply, where he discussed his comments, that provides tantalizing hints about the workings of the Cabinet and the scale of disagreement over foreign policy.

As Patel described, he was almost hustled into having a meeting by restive Congress MPs unhappy with the Prime Minister's policy vis-à-vis Pakistan, where he mostly attempted to pacify their anger, advised them against raising the issue in any public fora and to wait for a resolution of the concerned issue without creating any bitterness. He made it a point to reiterate that he had always worked to strengthen Nehru's hand and given him loyal support, even subjecting himself to 'considerable self-restraint' in the process. He could not recall a single instance when he had asserted himself against any determined course of policy that Nehru had outlined – nor could he remember a single instance where his difference of opinion had led him to oppose Nehru in the Cabinet with regard to any action that Nehru had deemed proper. In his own words: 'As regards Pakistan in general and East Bengal in particular, there is undoubtedly a difference in our approach … While expressing my view in favour of a firm policy and a